Virtual University ENG 101
Lesson -23

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Dear students, we looked at different kinds of sentences in the last lesson, simple compound and complex .

In today's lesson we will focus on writing effective sentences by looking at issues like the unity of a sentence and the emphasis in a sentence.

Let us begin…..

Lesson 23 Effective Sentences

- **What is it that makes sentences effective?**

  There are three elements which make for effectiveness in sentences: unity, coherence and emphasis.

- By **unity** we mean that every part of a sentence / composition must contribute to one main, unifying thought.

- By **coherence** we mean that the various parts of a sentence / composition must follow one another in an order which makes their relationship clear.

• By **emphasis** we mean that the most important parts of a sentence / composition must be so placed that attention is directed toward them rather than toward less important parts.

I. Unity: A good sentence should have unity, that is, it must express one main idea. Although a sentence may contain more than one fact, all the facts must relate to the main idea. e.g. *The models were all dressed in the latest fashions and many of them are unemployed.* This sentence does not have unity. The first clause tell us about the model's clothing,

e.g. *The models were all dressed in the latest fashions and many of them are unemployed.*

while the second one mentions unemployment ; the two different ideas don't belong together in one sentence. They should be stated in two separate sentences. This sentence is a sample of a sentence that lacks unity. Unity is violated in five ways:

(i) by combining unrelated ideas

(ii) putting too many ideas / details in a single sentence

(iii) failure to complete an idea or grammatical construction

(iv) subordination

(v) parallelism

(i) combining unrelated ideas e.g. *The students at the college use a great deal of abusive language and they are from all parts of the country.*

(ii) Too many ideas or details put in a single sentence distract the reader from the main thought of the sentence e.g. *Reading his daily newspaper that morning, standing at the crowded bus stop, the morning sun just lighting up the tops of the high buildings and making the sleepy-eyed people shade their eyes, made a great impression on me.*

EXAMPLES

i. *The students at the college use a great deal of abusive language and they are from all parts of the country.*

ii. *Reading his daily newspaper that morning, standing at the crowded bus stop, the morning sun just lighting up the tops of the high buildings and making the sleepy-eyed people shade their eyes, made a great impression on me.*

(iii) Failure to complete an idea or a grammatical construction: such sentences are the result of carelessness on the part of the writer who thinks that the reader will not object to filling in the gaps in the thought e.g. - *This is such a heavy chair.*

- I was so pleased about the letter.

- The news is too wonderful.

All these expressions can be improved by adding a clause or substituting another word for <u>such</u>, <u>so</u> and <u>too</u>. e.g.

iii. *- This is such a heavy chair.*

- I was so pleased about the letter.

- The news is too wonderful.

-This is <u>such</u> a heavy chair ***that it is not easy to carry.***

- I was <u>so</u> pleased about the letter ***that I ran to tell my mother.***

-The news is <u>too</u> wonderful ***to be believed*** */ The news is* ***indeed wonderful.***

- *This is <u>such</u> a heavy chair* ***that it is not easy to carry.***
- *I was <u>so</u> pleased about the letter* ***that I ran to tell my mother.***
- *The news is <u>too</u> wonderful* ***to be believed*** *or the news is* ***indeed wonderful.***

Some clauses express complete thoughts and others do not. Those that express complete thoughts are **independent** or **main** clauses, others are called **dependent** or **subordinate** clauses. Now if a sentence contains not one single thought but a complete thought containing a number of constituent thoughts, then you have to decide which of the several ideas is the main idea and which ideas are subordinate and then so construct the sentence that the subordinate thoughts will give emphasis to the main thought.

When you place the principal or main thought in a subordinate position unity of the sentence is destroyed. e.g.

(Faulty) *The fielder in the slips dropped the third catch, when the match was definitely lost.*

(Improved) *When the fielder in the slips dropped the third catch the match was definitely lost.*

The fielder in the slips dropped the third catch, when the match was definitely lost
(Faulty)

Consider these statements:

He was born of poor parents. He was obliged to work his way through college. He graduated with honours at the heads of his class.

Two of these statements may be subordinated to the third.

Although he was born of poor parents and was obliged to work his way through college, he graduated with honours at the head of his class.

Consider these statements:

He was born of poor parents. He was obliged to work his way through college. He graduated with honours at the heads of his class.

Practice 1: The following sentences can be improved by using the correct connectives and making the subordinate thoughts give emphasis to the main thought.

1. I was reaching down to pick up my cap just as I saw the two snakes.

- Just as I was reaching down to pick up my cap, I saw the two snakes.

2. We came within sight of the village when our car suddenly caught fire.

- When we came within sight of the village our car suddenly caught fire.

Practice 1: The following sentences can be improved by using the correct connectives and making the subordinate thoughts give emphasis to the main thought.

1. I was reaching down to pick up my cap just as I saw the two snakes.

2. We came within sight of the village when our car suddenly caught fire.

3. Because he has been to college is no sign he is cultured.

- The fact that he has been to college is no sign that he is cultured.

4. The main reason I left early was <u>because</u> I was bored.

- The main reason I left early was <u>that</u> I was bored. (wrong subordinating connective)

5. Mr. Jamshed is the Vice President while Mr. Saeed is the Secretary.

- Mr. Jamshed is the Vice President and Mr. Saeed is the Secretary. (Co-ordination conjunction)

3. Because he has been to college is no sign he is cultured.

4. The main reason I left early was <u>because</u> I was bored.

5. Mr. Jamshed is the Vice President while Mr. Saeed is the Secretary.

Practice 2: The following sentences are lacking in unity. Improve them by adding details & changing words where necessary.

1. The librarian was so discouraged about the lack of funds.

- The librarian was extremely discouraged about the lack of funds.

2. Our situation is too wonderful.

- Our situation is wonderful.

Practice 2: The following sentences are lacking in unity. Improve them by adding details & changing words where necessary.

1. The librarian was so discouraged about the lack of funds.

2. Our situation is too wonderful.

3.Trying to work when my neighbour is playing his drum is such a problem.
-Trying to work when my neighbour is playing his drum is a great problem.

4. The young ladies wore bright coloured socks and were kind hearted.
- The young ladies wore bright coloured socks. Inspite of their odd manner of dress they were, we found, essentially kind hearted.

3.Trying to work when my neighbour is playing his drum is such a problem.

4. The young ladies wore bright coloured socks and were kind hearted.

5. She is so talented.
- She is very talented.

6. Computer courses have more appeal for the college student today.
- Computer courses have more appeal for the college student today than have arts courses.

These sentences you noticed were improved by adding a clause / statement, or substituting another word for **so, too** & **such**.

5. She is so talented.

6. Computer courses have more appeal for the college student today.

We have seen that less important ideas must be made subordinate to the main idea of a sentence. However, if two ideas are co-ordinate, they must be given equal rank in the sentence. This is known as **parallelism**. Students very often use faulty parallelism. Great care must be used in the matter of parallel structure. Nouns must be parallel to nouns, verbs to verbs, subordinate clauses to subordinate clauses gerunds to gerunds, etc…..

The following sentences are examples of faulty constructions.

(a) *-She told me <u>to look</u> on the table and that I <u>should tell</u> her what I found.*
(Improved) She told me <u>to look</u> on the table and <u>to tell</u> her what I found.

(b) *-Seema's job <u>is reading</u> books and <u>to write</u> book reviews.*
(Improved) Seema's job is reading books and writing book reviews.

The following sentences are examples of faulty constructions.

(a) *She told me <u>to look</u> on the table and that I <u>should tell</u> her what I found.*

(b) *Seema's job <u>is reading</u> books and <u>to write</u> book reviews.*

(c) -*He was considerate, friendly, and people respected him.*

(Improved) He was considerate, friendly and respected by people.

(d) -*The couple want to travel extensively and new experiences.*

(Improved) The couple want to travel extensively and to have new experiences

(c) *He was considerate, friendly, and people respected him.*

(d) *The couple want to travel extensively and new experiences.*

(e) -The professor drew attention to the beginning of the revolution and how it ended.
(Improved) The professor drew attention to the beginning and end of the revolution.

(f) -Getting the groceries, taking the children to school and to feed the dog are his daily tasks.
(Improved) Getting the groceries, taking the children to school and feeding the dog are his daily tasks.

(e) The professor drew attention to the beginning of the revolution and how it ended.

(f) Getting the groceries, taking the children to school and to feed the dog are his daily tasks.

NOTE:(1) It is often necessary to repeat preposition or other words in order to make parallelism clear. e.g. *For lunch I had an apple pie and banana.*
(Improved) For lunch I had an apple pie and a banana.

(2) Correlatives (either…or / not only… also) should be used only with parallel elements.
He not only likes tennis but also golf.
(Improved) He likes not only tennis but also golf.

NOTE 1: e.g. *For lunch I had an apple pie and banana.*

Correlatives *2. He not only likes tennis but also golf.*

You must bear in mind that faulty parallelism is worse than no parallelism at all. You should use parallelism freely in your sentences but should resist all temptation to force into parallel structure clauses which are not parallel in thought.

Practice 3: The following sentences contain errors in parallelism. Correct the errors.

1. Swimming and to go fishing are my favourite sports.

- Swimming and fishing are my favourite sports.

Practice 3: The following sentences contain errors in parallelism. Correct the errors.

1. Swimming and to go fishing are my favourite sports.

2. I both want exercise and to be amused.
- I want both exercise and amusement.

3. He offered either to pay for it now or tomorrow.
- He offered to pay for it either now or tomorrow.
4. Not only were they disappointed but also angry.
- They were not only disappointed but also angry.

2. I both want exercise and to be amused.

3. He offered either to pay for it now or tomorrow.

4. Not only were they disappointed but also angry.

5. As we were unfamiliar with the route and because of approaching darkness, we decided to ask for advice.

-As we were unfamiliar with the route and as darkness was approaching, we decided to ask for advice.

6. The boy's face was streaked with dirt and his feet muddy.

- The boy's face was streaked with dirt and his feet were muddy.

5. As we were unfamiliar with the route and because of approaching darkness, we decided to ask for advice.

6. The boy's face was streaked with dirt and his feet muddy.

II. So far we have looked at how the unity of sentences is destroyed. Now we shall turn to the second element, **coherence**, which helps to create an effective sentence. A sentence has coherence when the various parts follow one another in an order which makes their relationship clear.

Correct handling of matters of unity, parallelism and subordination contributes to coherence. When working for coherence there are 4 pitfalls which must be avoided at all costs. These are weak, general or ambiguous reference of pronouns, split constructions, use of mixed constructions and mixed figures of speech and needless shifting from one point of view to another – all these destroy coherence in a sentence.

1. Reference of Pronouns: A pronoun must have an antecedent, i.e.; a previous reference that it must agree with in person, number and gender. You must avoid weak, vague, general or ambiguous reference. e.g.

(i) *Ahmed saw Basit and Zahid yesterday and he said that he had the money.* (ambig) - *Ahmed saw Basit and Zahid yesterday, and Zahid told him he had the money* (Improved).

1. Reference of Pronouns: e.g.

(i) *Ahmed saw Basit and Zahid yesterday and he said that he had the money.* (ambig)

(ii) *My aunt's cat was crippled; and she was never the same again* . (ambiguous aunt, cat?)
- *My aunt was never the same again after her cat was crippled.* (Improved)

(iii) *She put the computer on the table, which her sister had bought.*
- *She put the computer which her sister had bought upon the table.* (Improved)

(ii) *My aunt's cat was crippled; and she was never the same again* . (ambiguous aunt, cat?)

(iii) *She put the computer on the table, which her sister had bought.*

Note: Don’t treat an antecedent first as singular and then as plural. e.g.

(i) *The Guard Company is now using coal in their furnaces instead of fuel oil.*
- The Guard Company is now using coal in its furnaces instead of fuel oil.

(ii) The club has done their best to raise the money.
- The club has done its best to raise the money.

Note: Don’t treat an antecedent first as singular and then as plural. e.g.

(i) *The Guard Company is now using coal in their furnaces instead of fuel oil.*

(ii) The club has done their best to raise the money.

2. Split Constructions: Words that are closely related to each other when separated influence the effectiveness of a sentence.

e.g.: (i) *The batsman started to viciously hit the stumps.*

- The batsman started to hit viciously the stumps.

(ii) *If we had the time, we could make some changes, if we wanted to.*

- If we had the time and if we wanted to, we could make some changes.

Usually a slight change in the word order is sufficient to remove this irregularity.

2. Split Constructions: e.g.

(i) *The batsman started to viciously hit the stumps.*

(ii) *If we had the time, we could make some changes, if we wanted to.*

3. Students often get their sentences and figures of speech badly tangled. This is usually due to:

(a) badly constructed sentences

(b) inappropriate figures of speech crowded together without regard for consistency: e.g.

(a)Bad construction

i.This is the book to which I was referring to.

-This is the book to which I was referring. (Improved)

(a)Bad construction

i.This is the book to which I was referring to.

(ii) *This author gives the best idea of the problem than any other I have read.*
-This author gives a better idea of the problem than any other I have read.
(Improved)

(b) mixture of figures of speech

e.g. *My castles in air came tumbling down into a bottomless heap.*

(ii) *This author gives the best idea of the problem than any other I have read.*

(b) mixture of figures of speech

e.g. *My castles in air came tumbling down into a bottomless heap.*

4. Aimless **shifting** from one point of view to another will destroy coherence in a sentence. This can be due to a needless shift from (a) active to passive (b) from singular to plural (c)from past tense to present. e.g.

(i) *He ran to the station and the train was taken by him.* (active to passive)

-He ran to the station and took the train.

(Improved)

4. Aimless **shifting** from one point of view to another will destroy coherence in a sentence. This can be due to a needless shift from (a) active to passive (b) from singular to plural (c)from past tense to present. e.g.

(i) *He ran to the station and the train was taken by him.* (active to passive)

(ii) *If one tries hard, they can accomplish much.* (singular to plural)

- If one tries hard, one can accomplish much.

(iii) The only words that we were able to distinguish are 'horse' and 'cart'.(pt to present)

- The only words that we were able to distinguish were 'horse' and 'cart'.

(ii) *If one tries hard, they can accomplish much.* (singular to plural)

(iii) The only words that we were able to distinguish are 'horse' and 'cart'.(pt to present)

Practice 4: The following sentences lack coherence. Try to make them better.

1. Susan and her sister both saw the film, but she was disappointed.

- Both Susan and her sister saw the film, but Susan was disappointed with it.

2. I wrote and asked my uncle to let me know about the books as soon as he can.

- I wrote to my uncle and asked him to let me know about the books as soon as he could.

Practice 4: The following sentences lack coherence. Try to make them better.

1. Susan and her sister both saw the film, but she was disappointed.

2. I wrote and asked my uncle to let me know about the books as soon as he can.

3. He took an oath to never, no matter what happened, reveal the secrets of the organization.
- He took an oath never to reveal the secrets of the organization, no matter what happened.

4. She is as old if not older than Henry.
- She is as old as Henry, if not older.

3. He took an oath to never, no matter what happened, reveal the secrets of the organization.

4. She is as old if not older than Henry.

5. We have and will again talk to him about his plans.
- We have talked to him and we will talk to him again about his plans.

6. She, having worked steadily at the sewing machine for three hours and having finished stitching five dresses, she sat down wearily in the armchair.
- Having worked steadily at the sewing machine for three hours and having finished stitching five dresses, she sat down wearily in the armchair.

5. We have and will again talk to him about his plans.

6. She, having worked steadily at the sewing machine for three hours and having finished stitching five dresses, she sat down wearily in the armchair.

III. The third element involved in making sentences effective is **Emphasis**. It is sometimes necessary to emphasize a particular word or phrase in order to sharpen the point / idea of the sentence. Emphasis may be achieved in several ways.

(a) **Position:** In English sentences the final position is reserved for the idea felt to be the most important. e.g. (i) *Her son graduated with honours, we were told.*

- Her son, we were told, graduated with honours.

III. Emphasis.

(a) **Position:** e.g.

(i) *Her son graduated with honours, we were told.*

(ii) You shall be called a liar, in all probability. (weak)

- You shall, in all probability, be called a liar.

(iii) She flatly refused to see him, for some unknown reason.

- For some unknown reason, she flatly refused to see him.

(ii) You shall be called a liar, in all probability. (weak)

(iii) She flatly refused to see him, for some unknown reason.

(b) Order of Climax: Ideas may be arranged in the order of climax but only if the ideas are of varying importance. e.g.
During his long stay with the club he served as president, secretary, treasurer and vice president.
- During his long stay with the club he served as treasurer, secretary, vice president and president. (order of importance)

(b) Order of Climax: e.g.

During his long stay with the club he served as president, secretary, treasurer and vice president.

(c) Repetition of important words will sometimes give the desirable emphasis. e.g. *The dog was his only friend, his only companion, his only confidant, and his only heir.*

-The repetition of 'his only' stresses the uniqueness of the dog in this person's life. Repetition can easily become boring and should be used sparingly. This is an example of deliberate repetition designed to make the sentence forceful.

(c) Repetition e.g.

i) The dog was his only friend, his only companion, his only confidant and his only heir.

Thoughtless or careless repetition of words has the opposite effect. e.g. *They believe that most of us believe they are lazy.*
- They believe that most of us consider them lazy. (Improved)

(d) Inversion / Altering Word-order is also a technique for creating emphasis. Here the natural word order of certain words or phrases in a sentence is changed and these words or phrases are placed where they will have more striking effect. e.g. :

e.g. ii) *They believe that most of us believe they are lazy.*

Poor though he was, he still gave money to charity.

The natural order would be "Though he was poor,…" but inverting the order of subject and object, the fact that the man was 'poor' is emphasized. e.g. *(i) I have never seen anything like it in my life.* (Natural Order)

- *Never in my life have I seen anything like it.* (Emphatic)

Like other devices, inversion must be used sparingly.

e.g.

(i) I have never seen anything like it in my life. (Natural Order)

Practice 5: The following sentences can be made more emphatic.

1. He testified that he had passed college, middle school and high school examinations.

- He testified that he had passed middle school, high school and college examinations.

2. We were informed by the doctor that the young girl had been told of her mother's death by him.

The doctor informed us that he had told the young girl of her mother's death.

Practice 5: The following sentences can be made more emphatic.

1. He testified that he had passed college, middle school and high school examinations.

2. We were informed by the doctor that the young girl had been told of her mother's death by him.

3. Go away, if you don't like it here.
- If you don't like it here, go away.

4. His mother is one person he can confide in.
- His mother is one person in whom he can confide.

5. My sister is happy in her new house, on the other hand.
- My sister, on the other hand, is happy in her new house.

3. Go away, if you don't like it here.

4. His mother is one person he can confide in.

5. My sister is happy in her new house, on the other hand.

6. It is a worthy cause, I think.

- *I think it is a worthy cause.*

In today's lesson we considered the general elements - unity coherence and emphasis which make for effectiveness in sentences. We shall continue with sentence construction in the next few lessons.

6. It is a worthy cause, I think.

With this we come to the end of this lesson. I hope it will help you construct more effective sentences in your academic as well as professional lives.

Okay then,see you next time.
Allah Hafiz